

WEEKLY JOURNAL DIGEST

Weekly journal digest for 2026-06-29 to 2026-07-05

Curated articles in political communication and computational social science.

SUMMARY

COMAP Journal Bot reviewed 237 collected candidates for the 2026-06-29 to 2026-07-05 digest window. After manual relevance filtering, this curated brief keeps 17 new articles and 19 previous-week catch-up items, with no late additions.

This is a particularly strong week for platform governance, authoritarian information control, and AI-assisted measurement. The new articles connect recommendation algorithms in China, Community Notes moderation, DSA-era platform access, partisan-media measurement, state surveillance, local news loss, and LLM-based decision-reason coding. The catch-up section adds useful work on authoritarian-preference contagion, foreign-news measurement, police legitimacy, work scheduling policy, political selection in China, and social-media negativity.

- Platform governance and digital democracy are the clearest through-line, spanning X Community Notes, DSA data access, partisan media effects, child online safety, and local newspaper decline.
- Authoritarian control appears in both institutional and informational forms: bureaucrat assignment, surveillance, social contagion of authoritarian preferences, and visual cues in Chinese elite selection.
- AI-for-CSS is represented by validated LLM workflows for decision-reason extraction and foreign-news measurement, plus broader AI governance and privacy concerns.

HIGHLIGHTS

Recommending the state: How social media algorithms curate state-created content in China

JOURNAL OF COMMUNICATION · 2026-07-03

Yingdan Lu; Xinyi Liu; Carl Zhou

Why it matters · A direct hit for COMAP interests: the article shows how recommendation systems can amplify state-created content in China, extending authoritarian information control beyond censorship and overt propaganda.

[Open article →](#)

Community Notes undermoderate polarizing content by design creating risks in electoral processes

SCIENCE ADVANCES · 2026-07-03

Paul Bouchaud; Pedro Ramaciotti

Why it matters · This is a platform-governance paper with immediate election relevance, showing how a consensus-seeking moderation design can leave polarizing electoral content under-moderated.

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State surveillance and collective dissent

AMERICAN JOURNAL OF POLITICAL SCIENCE · 2026-07-01

Gaetan Nandong

Why it matters · The theory connects surveillance, repression expectations, and citizen coordination, giving the lab a clean framework for thinking about digital authoritarian control and dissent.

[Open article →](#)

Platform Collective Behavior as Democratic Infrastructure: Beyond Causal Effects in the DSA Era

POLITICAL COMMUNICATION · 2026-06-30

Anja Bechmann

Why it matters · It reframes platform influence as emergent collective behavior and evaluates whether DSA researcher access is enough to study democratic systemic risks.

[Open article →](#)

Large language models accurately identify decision reasons in verbal reports

PROCEEDINGS OF THE NATIONAL ACADEMY OF SCIENCES · 2026-06-30

Kamil Fuawka; Ralph Hertwig; Dirk U. Wulff

Why it matters · The paper offers a validated LLM workflow for extracting decision reasons from verbal reports, a useful model for AI-assisted measurement in computational social science.

[Open article →](#)

Bureaucrat assignments as instruments of political control: Theory and evidence from land administration officials in India

AMERICAN JOURNAL OF POLITICAL SCIENCE · 2026-07-02

Anustubh Agnihotri; Aditya Dasgupta; Devesh Kapur

Why it matters · The article shows how personnel assignment can become a political-control instrument, with evidence from land administration and corruption incentives in India.

[Open article →](#)

Is support for authoritarian rule contagious? Evidence from field and survey experiments

AMERICAN JOURNAL OF POLITICAL SCIENCE · 2026-06-27

Sirianne Dahlum; Torbjørn Hanson; Ashild Johnsen; Andreas Kotsadam; Alexander Wuttke

Why it matters · The experiments suggest authoritarian preferences can move through social influence, making anti-democratic support a social-contagion problem rather than only an individual attitude.

[Open article →](#)

NEClass: a lightweight LLM pipeline for measuring Foreign news coverage

COMMUNICATION METHODS AND MEASURES · 2026-06-24

Tobias Schmidt

Why it matters · NEClass is a practical LLM-supported measurement pipeline for cross-national news coverage, with validation details that are directly relevant to computational communication work.

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Previous Week Catch-Up

- [Communication Research](#)
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COLLECTION SNAPSHOT		
TOTAL COLLECTED CANDIDATES 237	NEW THIS WEEK CANDIDATES 142	PREVIOUS WEEK CATCH-UP CANDIDATES 95
LATE ADDITIONS CANDIDATES 0	CURATED DIGEST BELOW 17 new, 19 catch-up, 0 late additions	NOTE The full collected set above is before manual relevance filtering, while the attached PDF reflects the curated digest.

FULL CURATED DIGEST

New This Week

Journal of Communication

Recommending the state: How social media algorithms curate state-created content in China

2026-07-03 · DOI 10.1093/JOC/JQAG010

Yingdan Lu; Xinyi Liu; Carl Zhou

College of Communication, University of Amsterdam , Amsterdam,; Department of Communication Studies, Northwestern University , Evanston, IL,

Abstract. Abstract Authoritarian governments have increasingly expanded their social media presence, producing massive content to shape public opinion and behavior. However, less is known about how social media algorithms curate such content and serve authoritarian political goals. This study theorizes algorithmic promotional curation, whereby recommendation algorithms systematically amplify state-created content, and empirically examines this curation through analyzing 119,064 trending and recommended videos from Bilibili, one of China's largest video-sharing platforms. Using descriptive analyses, regression models, and Markov chain simulations, we find that state-created content is disproportionately amplified through video recommendations associated with state-created trending videos, and that state-affiliated accounts exhibit strong self-reinforcement. Yet this algorithmic promotional curation is not uniform across content categories, with stronger amplification among state-created news and politics than other content. These findings demonstrate how recommendation systems may subtly serve authoritarian goals, advance a multilateral understanding of algorithmic curation, and extend authoritarian information control frameworks beyond censorship and propaganda.

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Science Advances

Community Notes undermoderate polarizing content by design creating risks in electoral processes

2026-07-03 · DOI 10.1126/SCIADV.AEE6932

Paul Bouchaud; Pedro Ramaciotti

CAMS EHESS, Paris, France.; Complex Systems Institute of Paris Ile-de-France CNRS, Paris, France.; Learning Planet Institute, CY Cergy Paris University, Paris, France.; medialab, Sciences Po, Paris, France.

Abstract. Community Notes of X enables users to collaboratively moderate misleading content. To resolve conflicting moderation, Community Notes infers a latent ideological dimension and selects notes garnering cross-partisan support. As this system is now deployed worldwide, we evaluate its operation across diverse polarization contexts. We analyze all 1.9 million moderation notes receiving 135 million ratings by March 2025, cross-referencing ideological scaling data on 13 countries. Our results show that the Community Notes algorithm effectively captures the main polarizing dimensions across countries, surfacing notes that garner cross-partisan support. This also means that, by design, Community Notes systematically undermoderate polarizing content. We analyze notes relating to four recent elections in the United States (2024), the United Kingdom (2024), France (2024), and Germany (2025) and demonstrate that they are systematically undermoderated when compared to other notes, posing potential risks to civic discourse and electoral processes.

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American Journal of Political Science

Bureaucrat assignments as instruments of political control: Theory and evidence from land administration officials in India

2026-07-02 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70069

Anustubh Agnihotri; Aditya Dasgupta; Devesh Kapur

Department of Political Science Ashoka University Sonapat Haryana India; Department of Political Science University of California Merced California USA; Paul H. Nitze School of Advanced International Studies (SAIS) Johns Hopkins University Washington DC USA

Abstract. Abstract This paper investigates how politicians use the assignment of officials to geographical posts-a personnel system found in many countries-as a system of incentives to control, and possibly corrupt, bureaucratic behavior. The argument is developed with a matching model and tested with a nationwide survey of Indian officials who administer land, a lucrative asset and source of rents in fastgrowing countries. With an unobtrusive design, we provide evidence that officials prefer geographical posts with urban amenities, good staffing, and hometown proximity. These preferences are intense in salaryequivalent terms. Ruling parties use this as leverage to exert pressure on officials to bend regulations by assigning them to their preferred posts but threatening transfers should they fail to comply, especially in jurisdictions with high regulatory corruption potential (measured with remotesensing data on flow of ruraltourban land transactions). The findings highlight personnel policy as a potent instrument of political control/corruption of bureaucracy.

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State surveillance and collective dissent

2026-07-01 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70057

Gaetan Nandong

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Abstract. Abstract State surveillance facilitates the collection of intelligence on dissidents while simultaneously providing information about the value of the status quo. I study this tradeoff in a context where an uninformed government must decide whether to repress. Because citizens expect more informed governments to enact greater repression, autocratic surveillance can create a climate of fear. However, surveillance can also stimulate dissent when citizens have access to public information. State surveillance gives citizens an opportunity to coordinate, even in the absence of a preference for such coordination. Surveillance can amplify dissent by enhancing citizens' motivations for political activism aimed at drawing the government's attention to political and economic issues. Coordination distorts government learning, resulting in lower expected levels of repression. The analysis further indicates that the effectiveness of advanced surveillance technology depends on expectations regarding repression, thereby underscoring a psychological aspect of state control.

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Science

Institutionalizing AI diplomacy in Africa

2026-07-02 · DOI 10.1126/SCIENCE.AEI7835

Chinasa T. Okolo

Chinasa T. Okolo is the founder and scientific director of Technecultura, Washington, DC, USA and the Editor-in-Chief of ACM SIGCAS Computers and Society, a publication of the Association for Computing Machinery.

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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From Edison's Invention Factory to the new architecture of innovation

2026-07-02 · DOI 10.1126/SCIENCE.AEI5415

Ashish Arora; Sharon Belenzon

Fuqua School of Business, Duke University, Durham, NC, USA.; National Bureau of Economic Research, Cambridge, MA, USA.

Abstract. Shifts reflect the maturation of institutions surrounding science

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Nature

Six ways to put the public at the heart of science and policy

2026-07-01 · DOI 10.1038/D41586-026-01981-Z

Chris Tyler; K. L. Akerlof; Musa al-Gharbi; Bjrn Bedsted; Laura Boeira; Tracey Brown; Elizabeth Christopherson; Dietram A. Scheufele; Mahmud Farooque; Brian W. Head; Tepring Piquado; David Budtz Pedersen

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Scientists should recognize their own political biases to build public trust

2026-07-01 · DOI 10.1038/D41586-026-01975-X

Mark Henderson

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Child online safety needs more than social-media bans

2026-06-30 · DOI 10.1038/D41586-026-02068-5

Kit-Aun Tan

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Nature Human Behaviour

An effort recalibration framework for digital media use and cognition

2026-07-01 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02500-W

Wisnu Wiradhany; Douglas Parry; Jaan Aru

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Political Communication

Does the Method Affect the Outcome? How Measures of Partisan Slant of Media Outlets and Affective Polarization Drive Results About Polarization in the United States

2026-07-05 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2699105

Christian Schemer; Klara Langmann; Ariel Hasell; Brian Weeks

Johannes Gutenberg University of Mainz; University of Michigan

Abstract. There is abundant evidence that partisan media use is related to polarization in the United States. However, there is less agreement on whether the outcomes of this exposure are detrimental to democracies. Different methods used to measure both partisan media use and polarization may have contributed to the variation in findings in this area of research. The present study relied on survey data from the 2020 U.S. presidential election to systematically examine how methodological differences in determining the partisanship of news outlets and polarization can impact outcomes of interest, such as the correlation between outlet-level partisan slant and affective as well as belief polarization. A specification curve analysis of 504 different ways of operationalizing these independent and dependent variables provided evidence that methodological choices considerably affected the strength of the relationship between partisan media use and affective and belief polarization.

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Platform Collective Behavior as Democratic Infrastructure: Beyond Causal Effects in the DSA Era

2026-06-30 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2679475

Anja Bechmann

Department of Media and Journalism, Aarhus University

Abstract. Online platforms have become infrastructural to democratic life, yet their influence is often examined through narrow causal-effect models that overlook systemic socio-technical dynamics. This Forum contribution introduces the concept of platform collective behavior to conceptualize how intertwined human-AI agency generates population-level patterns with systemic risk implications for democracy and citizen well-being. Rather than focusing on isolated persuasion effects, platform collective behavior captures emergent socio-algorithmic patterns such as unequal political participation, differential exposure to misinformation, bot amplification, and subgroup information segregation. The article evaluates whether Article 40 of the European Digital Services Act (DSA), which grants vetted researchers access to platform data, enables robust investigation of such systemic risks. While the DSA represents an unprecedented regulatory intervention in research data access, its scope is limited to systemic risks and depends on platform-provided datasets. The analysis identifies blind spots, including infrastructural and economic power asymmetries, offline behavioral consequences, and data integrity concerns. The article concludes that DSA access is necessary but insufficient for fully assessing platform influence on democracy.

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Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences

People in more individualist cultures are more motivated to make others feel better

2026-06-30 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2533994123

Shir Ginosar Yaari; Yulia Chentsova-Dutton; Michaela Riediger; Antje Rauters; Min Young Kim; Yuri Miyamoto; Allon Vishkin; Julia Anne Freitag; Jan Cieciuch; Mariana Gurevich; Maria Padun; Nevin Solak; Xiaoqin Wang; Jiang Qiu; Aldo Alvarez-Risco; Alessandro Alberto Rossi; Yaniv Hanoach; Yukiko Uchida; Claudio Vaz Torres; Thiago Gomes Nascimento; Asghar Afshar Jahanshahi; Rakesh Singh; Babita Singh; Shanmukh V. Kamble; Sieun An; Vivian Dzokoto; Adote Anum; Stefania Mannarini; Maria Isabel Huerta-Carvajal; Erika Galindo-Bello; Veronica Janneth Garcia Ibarra; Arobindu Dash; Maya Tamir

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Abstract. In many Western cultures, trying to make others feel better is considered critical for psychological health and social relationships. However, given that people think about emotions and relationships differently across cultures, the desirability, means, and benefits of making others feel better may also vary by culture. In two multicountry survey studies (Study 1: $N = 3,154$, 13 countries; Study 2: $N = 3,503$, 17 countries) and in a daily diary study (Study 3: $N = 243$, 2 countries), we assessed motivation and strategies used for influencing others' and one's own emotions. To test whether potential cross-cultural differences in motivation and strategies in emotion regulation are unique to social interactions, we compared cultural differences in making others feel better to making oneself feel better. Across studies, cultural differences in influencing others' emotions were greater than those in influencing one's own emotions. Members of more individualist (vs. collectivist) cultures were more motivated to make others (but not themselves) feel better, were more likely to express care and less likely to encourage others to suppress their emotions or to ruminate. These patterns, in turn, were linked to an index of relationship closeness in an individualist (but not a collectivist) culture. These findings suggest that helping others feel better may not be equally desirable across cultures.

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Large language models accurately identify decision reasons in verbal reports

2026-06-30 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2526798123

Kamil Fuawka; Ralph Hertwig; Dirk U. Wulff

Center Synergy of Systems, Dresden University of Technology; Center for Adaptive Rationality, Max Planck Institute for Human Development; Faculty of Psychology, University of Basel

Abstract. Understanding the reasons behind human choices under risk is a central goal of decision scientists, but traditional methods relying on behavioral data are limited by strict invariance assumptions. We introduce a scalable analytical framework using large language models (LLMs) to analyze verbal reports and identify articulated reasons for choice between monetary lotteries. A validated LLM accurately identified predefined decision reasons in participants' free-text reports, aligning with their actual choices in 95% of trials. Our analysis reveals that the reasons behind people's decisions vary systematically and are driven more by the structure of the choice problem than by individual differences. Crucially, reasons identified from verbal reports yield more parsimonious and informative representations of decision processes compared to those inferred from choices alone; furthermore, problem-specific reason profiles achieve out-of-sample prediction accuracy that is competitive with established computational models. This work demonstrates that verbal reports are a rich data source and our analytical framework can unlock their potential, delivering results that challenge the field's foundational invariance assumptions and pave the way for more context-sensitive and interpretable models of human decision making.

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Debt as a blessing: A capital screening mechanism

2026-06-30 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2602272123

Feng Dong; Thomas J. Sargent; Pengfei Wang; Yizhen Wang

Department of Economics, New York University; Peking University HSBC Business School; School of Economics and Management, Tsinghua University; School of Finance, Central University of Finance and Economics

Abstract. We challenge a recently popular view that a negative interest-growth rate gap ($r < g$) offers a "free lunch" for debt-financed government spending by formulating a model in which r and g are endogenous variables shaped by fiscal policy through its effects on equilibrium multiplicity and capital allocation. Observing $r < g$ can signal that sustained government deficits have generated multiple steady states, and the economy has converged to a stable low-efficiency equilibrium. With its heterogeneous entrepreneurs, the model's real interest rate serves as a screening device for investment efficiency.

Causation runs from the fiscal regime to equilibrium selection and outcomes: Fiscal surpluses eliminate equilibrium multiplicity and anchor expectations that sustain a unique, high-productivity equilibrium, thereby rationalizing Alexander Hamilton's characterization of "debt as a blessing." Persistent deficits can push the economy into a "misallocation trap" characterized by scarce safe assets, low interest rates, survival of inefficient firms, depressed aggregate productivity, and self-validating low growth. Thus, costs of debt-financed fiscal deficits consist not only of deferred taxes, but also of permanently lower national productive capacity.

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Local partisan context and mental health

2026-06-29 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2522718123

Ryan Baxter-King; Jacob R. Brown; Ryan D. Enos; Arash Naeim; Lynn Vavreck

Department of Government and Institute for Quantitative Social Science, Harvard University; Department of Political Science, Boston University; Department of Political Science, University of California, Los Angeles; Department of Political Science, University of Nevada; Division of Hematology-Oncology, Department of Medicine, University of California, Los Angeles

Abstract. We find that, relative to Republicans residing in more Republican neighborhoods, Republicans in neighborhoods with a higher concentration of Democratic residents report higher levels of anxiety, depression, and loneliness. While Democrats in general report worse mental health than Republicans, Democrats show no sensitivity to partisan context. Using a large-scale national survey and fine-grained data on residential political context, we establish that these patterns persist even when examining partisans who live in the same Zip Codes, and while controlling for other individual and geographic features. The correlation is strongest for the most strongly partisan individuals, suggesting that politics is a significant factor in the relationship. For Republicans, the size of the relationship between partisan context and mental health is comparable to or larger than the correlation between mental health reports and other contextual features of residential areas, such as neighborhood poverty or the way racial minorities respond to changes in the racial or ethnic composition of local geography.

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Communication Research

Partisanship in Context: The (A)symmetric Influence of Local Newspaper Availability and Selective Exposure on Political Misperceptions in the U.S.

2026-06-29 · DOI 10.1177/00936502261463581

Jianing Li; Michael W. Wagner

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Abstract. How people consume information and understand facts is an inherently multilevel problem, but inquiry frequently stops at the individual-level. We highlight how disparities in local newspaper availability across communities influence individuals' partisan selective exposure and congruent political misperceptions. Using a quasi-experimental design enabling comparisons of individuals living in counties with different local newspaper availability but otherwise matched features, we found that lacking a local newspaper in one's county is associated with a decrease in national mainstream media use. Moreover, lacking a local newspaper amplifies partisan selective consumption of liberal media, but not conservative media. Beliefs in falsehoods disseminated by elites from both major parties in the U.S. are influenced by selective exposure and amplified by local newspaper context, while liberal media use is more sensitive to the contextual variances in local news environments than conservative media use. Findings from this unique dataset are robust against various tests of confounding effects.

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Previous Week Catch-Up

Communication Research

Memorable Messages About Retirement, Own Communication About Financial Preparations for Retirement, and Successful Aging: Testing Theoretical Mechanisms in the Communicative Ecology Model of Successful Aging

2026-06-28 · DOI 10.1177/00936502261463578

Quinten S. Bernhold; Cole Jagger Lazerus Burns; Kylie Julius; Peyton Mills; Sarah Devereux; Traci Lively

University of Tennessee, Knoxville, USA

Abstract. This study addressed how communication about retirement fits in the communicative ecology model of successful aging (CEMSA). U.S. American older adults (N = 294, M Age = 59.27 years) reported on a memorable message they heard about retirement, as well as on their own talk about how they can be financially prepared for retirement. Older adults who wrote a memorable message with a theme of (a) saving money for retirement or (b) relaxing or enjoying life during retirement reported talking about how they can be financially prepared for retirement more than did older adults who did not write a memorable message with one of these themes. Older adults' talk about how they can be financially prepared for retirement was indirectly associated with successful aging, via the serial mediators of positive affect about aging and aging efficacy. Talking about how one can be financially prepared for retirement may be a worthwhile theoretical addition to the CEMSA.

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Fifty Years of Diversity in Communication and Media Studies (1974-2023): The Intertwined Trends in Geographic, Gender, and Methodological Representation

2026-06-22 · DOI 10.1177/00936502261454813

Mark Boukes; Irina Lock; Shujun Liu

Cardiff University, UK; Friedrich Schiller University Jena, Germany; University of Amsterdam, The Netherlands

Abstract. This study explored trends of diversity in Communication and Media Studies (CMS) between 1974 and 2023 through an automated content analysis of journal publications. An increasing proportion of first-authors from non-WEIRD countries and non-U.S. WEIRD countries was found alongside a declining proportion of U.S.-based scholars (WEIRD refers to "Western, Educated, Industrialized, Rich, and Democratic"). The visibility of women first-authors grew markedly to 54% in the 2020s, although still a bit below the benchmark. A growing prevalence of qualitative methods was found relative to quantitative methods and conceptual work. Interestingly, these trends were intertwined. Qualitative studies were more likely to be authored by women, by scholars from non-U.S. WEIRD countries, and based on non-WEIRD populations. Women authorship was less likely among the increasingly visible non-WEIRD and non-U.S. WEIRD first-authors. Furthermore, less diversity-in particular, geographic and methodological diversity (but not gender diversity)-was found in journals with higher impact-factor.

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American Journal of Political Science

Is support for authoritarian rule contagious? Evidence from field and survey experiments

2026-06-27 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70067

Sirianne Dahlum; Torbjørn Hanson; Ashild Johnsen; Andreas Kotsadam; Alexander Wuttke

Department of Political Science LMU Munich Munich Germany; Department of Political Science University of Oslo Oslo Norway; Norwegian Defense Research Establishment Kjeller Norway; Oslo Business School Oslo Metropolitan University Oslo Norway; Ragnar Frisch Centre for Economic Research Gaustadalleen Oslo Norway

Abstract. Abstract The increasing popularity of strongman rule in democratic societies underscores the need to explore how authoritarian regime preferences might spread socially. We assess the role of social influence on support for leaders with authoritarian inclinations through preregistered field and survey experiments in the Norwegian Armed Forces. The field experiment randomly assigned soldiers to different rooms during boot camp, so soldiers lived among peers with varying levels of openness to authoritarian rule. We found that many individuals adjusted their privately reported support for authoritarian rule to align more closely with their peers. Further surveyexperimental evidence among soldiers and the general Norwegian population confirms that learning about others' level of support for authoritarian rule changes both perceptions and own support. Our results suggest that support for authoritarian rule can have a social basis and could potentially spread through social contagion in established democracies.

[Read article →](#)

Getting on the grid: A field experiment on bottomup political pressure and access to essential public services

2026-06-27 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70068

Nikhil Gaikwad; Anjali Thomas

Assistant Professor, Department of Political Science Columbia University New York New York USA; Associate Professor, Sam Nunn School of International Affairs Georgia Institute of Technology Atlanta Georgia USA

Abstract. Abstract Water is essential for human life, yet governments frequently leave vulnerable citizens to rely on informal channels for access. What can motivate governments to provide public services such as water to citizens trapped in informality? We theorize how accessing state services involves distinct strategic interactions between citizens, bureaucrats, and politicians at different formalization stages. A large factorial field experiment in Mumbai's informal settlements reveals that a bureaucratic facilitation drive significantly improved citizens' ability to access municipal water connections in policyeligible settlements, but only when combined with a bottomup political coordination campaign targeting elected officials. While bureaucratic assistance helped citizens through the petitioning stage of the formalization process, political pressure was needed to ensure service delivery in the infrastructural stage more open to political influence. Our findings illuminate how specific citizen empowerment campaigns reshape the incentives of otherwise reluctant bureaucrats and politicians to provide marginalized groups their basic human rights.

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Rebuilding trust in national police: The case of the UN mission in Mali

2026-06-25 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70066

Nadine Ansorg; Zorzeta Bakaki; Jessica Di Salvatore

Associate Professor, Department of Government University of Essex Colchester UK; Associate Professor, Department of Political and Social Sciences University of Florence Florence Italy; Reader, Politics at Kent University of Kent Canterbury Kent UK

Abstract. Abstract International interventions often aim to reinforce both capacity as well as perceived legitimacy of national security forces. However, how peacekeeping operations manage to improve trust in the national police has received limited attention. In this article, we evaluate whether and how UN missions can (re)build trust in the national police focusing on the case of Mali. We combine data on UN local deployment and nationally representative survey rounds from the Afrobarometer. We use the wealth of information from the survey to disentangle the mechanisms linking UN peacekeeping to positive changes in trust in national police. Employing a differenceindifference estimation, we find that respondents in locations that hosted UN police report higher trust toward the national police forces compared to respondents in the control group. We find that this may be due to UN police improving perceptions of safety, accessibility to and integrity of national police forces.

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Nature

Inside the new political screening that's stalling NIH grants

2026-06-26 · DOI 10.1038/D41586-026-01924-8

*Max Kozlov***Abstract.** Abstract unavailable.[Read article →](#)**Disparate privacy risks from medical AI**

2026-06-24 · DOI 10.1038/S41586-026-10688-0

Moritz A. Knolle; Martin J. Menten; Friederike Jungmann; Felix Meissen; Ben Glocker; Daniel Rueckert; Georgios Kaissis

Abstract. Abstract Medical artificial intelligence (AI) models hold the promise to improve global access to high-quality diagnostics ¹. However, the training data underlying these models often contain sensitive patient information that may be exposed through privacy attacks ²⁻⁷. Previous research has primarily quantified the success of these attacks in aggregate, across all records in a dataset. Thus, the privacy risk faced by individual patients, who often contribute multiple similar records to a training dataset, is poorly understood. Here we present one of the first patient-level privacy audits of AI models for medical diagnostic applications. We focus on membership inference attacks ²⁻⁴ (MIAs), which seek to determine whether the data of a given individual were used to train a model. Across a diverse range of medical datasets, we show that MIAs can achieve near-perfect success rates for individual patients, even when the aggregate performance does not substantially deviate from random guessing. We further find that the number of patients with high attack success increases substantially with model capacity, and that underrepresented groups-stratified by disease status, self-reported race, insurance, sex or imaging protocol-face disproportionately high attack success. Together, our findings show that aggregate privacy metrics can severely underestimate individual privacy risk. Whether the disparate risk profiles we observe extend to attacks beyond MIAs remains an open question, motivating the further development of risk assessment and mitigation techniques that cater to all data-contributing patients.

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Science Advances

Fair Workweek laws in the US: An appraisal of intended and unintended consequences

2026-06-26 · DOI 10.1126/SCIADV.AEA8632

*Daniel Schneider; Kristen Harknett; David Arbelaez**Harvard Kennedy School, Cambridge, MA, USA.; University of California, San Francisco, San Francisco, CA, USA.*

Abstract. Fair Workweek laws, implemented in several large cities and one state, represent a new wave of innovation in a century of contestation and legislation around work time. Where previous legislation sought to regulate overwork, these laws aim to regulate work schedule instability and insufficiency of work hours, but evidence on their effects is incomplete. Using stacked difference-in-differences models and original survey data, we find robust evidence that Fair Workweek regulations led to increases in advance notice of schedules and time to rest between shifts and reductions in last-minute schedule changes. We find no evidence of compensatory retrenchment in other aspects of job quality. These average effects disguise substantial heterogeneity across jurisdictions, pointing to the importance of local enforcement in realizing policy goals. Fair Workweek legislation has realized some intended effects on work schedules without unintended consequences, but the potential for more widespread, effective enforcement has not been fully realized.

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Political Analysis

On the Foundations of the Design-Based Approach

2026-06-25 · DOI 10.1017/PAN.2026.10045

P. M. Aronow; Austin Jang; Molly Offer-Westort

University of Chicago Division of the Social Sciences; Yale University

Abstract. Abstract The design-based paradigm may be adopted in causal inference and survey sampling when we assume Rubin's stable unit treatment value assumption (SUTVA) or impose similar frameworks. While often taken for granted, such assumptions entail strong claims about the data-generating process. We develop an alternative design-based approach: we first invoke a generalized, non-parametric model that allows for unrestricted forms of interference, such as spillover. We define an associated set of inferential targets and discuss their interpretation under SUTVA and a weaker assumption that we call the "no unmodeled revealable variation assumption" (NURVA). We then reconstruct the standard paradigm, reconsidering SUTVA at the end rather than assuming it at the beginning. Despite its similarity to SUTVA, we demonstrate the practical limitations of NURVA alone for identifying substantively interesting quantities. In so doing, we provide clarity on the nature and importance of SUTVA for applied research.

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Science

The enduring pursuit of science in America

2026-06-25 · DOI 10.1126/SCIENCE.AEJ8205

Neil H. Shubin

Neil H. Shubin takes office on 1 July as president of the United States National Academy of Sciences, Washington, DC, USA.

Abstract. Imagine an American organization that convenes scientific experts not to advance any ideology or interest but to provide the nation with a clear understanding of complex problems. Imagine this body would follow the evidence rather than the headlines and earn its authority not through rhetoric or persuasion but careful and rigorous analysis and transparent processes. This institution exists-although its work faces pressing challenges-and it is more urgently needed today than at any point in living memory.

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Communication Methods and Measures

NEClass: a lightweight LLM pipeline for measuring Foreign news coverage

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Abstract. Understanding cross-national news coverage is central to international communication research. However, quantifying how countries appear in the news remains methodologically challenging: simple keyword counts lack context, while manual coding does not scale. This paper introduces NEClass, a reproducible, open-source pipeline that combines standard Named Entity Recognition (NER) with a fine-tuned Large Language Model (LLM) to classify entities' country affiliations. Unlike static dictionary approaches, NEClass leverages the latent world knowledge of modern LLMs and local context to resolve ambiguities dynamically. I demonstrate the pipeline's validity regarding country attribution (weighted F1 of

0.95), show that it performs more reliably than established baseline approaches (including keyword matching and zero-shot LLM prompting), and illustrate its utility through a case study of the Eurozone crisis coverage in German and Italian newspapers. Ultimately, NEClass provides researchers with a robust and accessible toolkit to operationalize international attention patterns beyond the limitations of purely keyword-based metrics.

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Political Communication

The Joe Rogan Experience: Epistemic Style Over Ideological Extremity in the Manosphere

2026-06-24 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2690998

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Abstract. Despite increasing prominence in the contemporary media ecosystem, podcasts have attracted limited scholarly attention. This study examines audience characteristics of the most popular podcast in the United States, The Joe Rogan Experience (JRE), situating it within the broader cultural context of the "manosphere." Leveraging two national probability samples collected in October 2022 (N = 2,907) and November 2023 (N = 1,000), this research explores the socio-demographic profile, information environment, epistemic orientations, identity, ideology, and trust of Rogan's listeners. Across both studies, among the strongest correlates of JRE listening is conservative media consumption, with additional associations with skeptical epistemic orientations, conspiracism, political and institutional distrust, and being young and male. In contrast, partisanship is not significantly associated with JRE listening once these other factors are included in the models. Contrary to common portrayals, hostile sexism, authoritarianism, and racial attitudes do not reliably predict JRE listening once media diet is accounted for. This research underscores the importance of examining audiences' deeper cultural values and epistemic orientations alongside traditional political variables, thereby clarifying our understanding of how influential media figures such as Rogan shape and reflect broader currents in an increasingly fragmented information environment.

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American Political Science Review

Efficient Production without Domination: The Case of Labor-Managed Firms

2026-06-23 · DOI 10.1017/S0003055426101750

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Abstract. Labor-managed firms, whether in the form of worker cooperatives, codetermination, or broad-based employee ownership, have recently prompted substantial public debate, to which political theorists have contributed with normative analyses that are seriously deficient insofar as they have neglected considerations of productive efficiency. I offer a normative view of labor-managed firms that leans squarely on efficiency considerations. I first argue that the value of productive efficiency is grounded not only on the interests of capital suppliers and society at large, but also on workers' interest in avoiding domination by their bosses, and examine how efficiency may serve and set back this interest. I next argue that some variants of labor-managed firms can secure efficient production while protecting workers' interest in nondomination more robustly than capital-controlled firms. Finally, I compare labor-managed firms to alternatives to achieve these aims, including self-employment, workplace regulation, unionization, and labor market policies to enhance workers' exit options.

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Portraits of Power: Facial Appearance and the Tacit Domain of Political Selection in China

2026-06-22 · DOI 10.1017/S0003055426101749

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Abstract. As the epitome of modern, rational organizations, bureaucracies are often believed to select candidates based on rules and reason. We argue that intuitive-and even instinctive-assessments of candidates' external appearances sometimes underpin seemingly rational and calculated decisions. Using a novel, AI-based algorithm that learns and reproduces human assessments of facial appearances at scale, we examine how perceived facial traits influence the careers of over four thousand mid- and senior-level Chinese officials. We find that officials who look more competent, trustworthy, and less aggressive enjoy significantly better promotion prospects and lower purge risk than their peers. Warmth-related traits (e.g., trustworthiness and non-aggressiveness) are especially valued at higher-level promotions and for male candidates. Additional analyses, including conjoint experiments with real officials, demonstrate that appearances' influence over selection preferences is comparable to performance or political connections. These findings challenge the prevailing meritocratic and relation-based theories of bureaucratic selection and highlight the role of impressions in the workings of government institutions.

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Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences

Three centuries of technological innovation: Opportunity is the mother of invention

2026-06-23 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2525310123

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Abstract. What socioecological conditions nurture the ingenuity and collaborative interactions underlying transformative technological innovations? We compiled a dataset on more than 400 major technological inventions from 1690 to 1990 spanning seven categories (agriculture, armaments, information and communication, household, industry, medical, and transportation) and performed inductive macroecological analyses to address how attributes of inventors, teams, and their social and geographic environments contributed to the innovation of new technologies that have changed the way people live. The vast majority of inventions were attributed to single inventors of various ages. The frequency, size, and cultural diversity of teams increased in the 20th Century, as did the proportion of inventions attributed to women and immigrants. A wide variety of environments acted as innovation hubs, including rural areas as well as specialized institutions and large cities. Invention rate (number of inventions per time period) peaked during the 1800s in cities, rural areas, and most categories but continued increasing over time in institutional environments and medical and communication technologies. The overall pattern across ages, genders, team attributes, environments, technological categories, and time periods supports the conclusion that opportunity, ingenuity, and environment all play key roles in the inventiveness phase of the innovation process: creative individuals in particular ecological environments and social settings come up with novel solutions to specific practical problems. Similar innovation patterns have been observed for tool use among nonhuman primates, highlighting unifying processes of innovation. Our macroecological approach offers valuable insights into the emergence and drivers of innovation and material culture.

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People prefer to negotiate with women, even when outcomes are identical and gender is unknown

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Abstract. While gender and economic outcomes in negotiation have been studied for decades, much less is known about gender differences in subjective outcomes, such as trust, rapport, and willingness to negotiate again, despite their importance for long-term success. In a series of studies with over 2,000 participants, we find that people consistently report better subjective outcomes when negotiating with women. This preference persists even in anonymous negotiations where gender is unknown and cannot be inferred from behavior, as well as in conditions where negotiation partner gender is randomly assigned. Importantly, we find no gender difference in economic outcomes. To understand why, we analyzed transcripts of real negotiations for any behavioral differences. These findings reveal an overlooked gender dynamic: While men and women achieve similar economic results, women foster stronger interpersonal relationships, which in turn lead to greater satisfaction and greater desire for future negotiations with women.

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Differentiation drives the erosion of positivity on social media

2026-06-22 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2527316123

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Abstract. Most people believe that social media discourse is negative and divisive. Here we show how this negativity can evolve even when users are not motivated to be negative. We propose that social media users seek to differentiate themselves from other users, and it is easier to differentiate oneself through negativity than positivity because negative information is more heterogeneous and counternormative than positive information. This makes users increasingly likely to post negative comments as a conversation unfolds and it becomes more challenging to make unique contributions. Analyzing 2.05 billion comments from 2,150 Reddit communities shows that comments become more negative over time, both within threads and community histories. This trend toward negativity is mediated by the semantic uniqueness of comments, suggesting that it arises from users differentiating themselves. This trend is strongest when initial dialogue is positive, making negative comments highly counternormative. We replicate these patterns in an experiment simulating social media dialogue ($n = 3,685$). Participants become more negative over time, but only when incentivized to be unique, and especially when dialogue begins positively. These findings suggest that the structure of social media platforms interacts with human motivation to foster a drift toward negativity over time in online discourse.

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Nature Human Behaviour

Political segregation in the US workplace

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Justin Frake; Reuben Hurst; Max Kagan

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Political polarization in low- and middle-income countries

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Horacio Larreguy; Ernesto Tiburcio

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